confess I augured very faintly on the success of his mission,' he wrote later, 'either from his manner or from his opinion "that the Afghans were to be treated as children".'[44] On one matter, however, the two agreed: the occupation of Peshawar was proving a financial disaster for the Sikhs, 'unprofitable, and a constant source of alarm and inquietude to Ranjit Singh', and the opportunity was now there to resolve the conflict by bringing the Sikhs, the Afghans and the Company together in an alliance that would keep Russian and Persian machinations at bay. 'Afghan affairs were capable of settlement,' Masson concluded, 'and the settlement was in our power at that time.'[45]

The second man to enter Burnes's camp was a much grander figure, and arrived that evening on elephant-back preceded by a 'fine body of Afghan cavalry'. This was Dost Mohammad's increasingly powerful fourth son, Mohammad Akbar Khan, whose path to fame had just begun when he had killed Hari Singh two months earlier. Akbar Khan was a strong, hard-bodied, hawk-faced young man. He resembled his father in his bravery, his charm, his ruthlessness and his sense of strategy, all qualities for which he was later celebrated as a heroic figure in Afghan song and epic poetry, where he appears as the Achilles, Roland and King Arthur of the Dari epic all rolled into one:[46]

> When Akbar the Brave, Master of the Sword
> Conquered and defeated the enemy forces
>
> When he fought the fierce armies of the Punjab
> He was but a youth, yet he had the mettle of a Sohrab
>
> He became a legend potent and brave
> As famed through the land as the mighty Rustam
>
> When he reached the season of his manhood
> He was tall and graceful as a young cypress
>
> He mastered every science
> And excelled in every art
>
> His luminous countenance shone with a light divine
> Worthy of crown and throne
>
> All the world was drawn to his face
> Every eye turned towards him[47]